

Abstract Algebra

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1 Group Theory

A lot of mathematics is not just about understanding the objects we use, but the structure behind them and the ways we can manipulate and transform them without changing their essential properties. In algebra, one of the most important structures is called a group. Groups capture the idea of symmetry, which at first sounds very simple; however, after developing the theory of groups, we will see that this simple idea of symmetry is only the starting point of a much deeper algebraic structure that unifies many seemingly unrelated mathematical systems.

1.1 Groups and examples

Definition 1.1 (Definition of a group). A group is a collection of elements in a set G along with a binary operation $*$: $G \times G \rightarrow G$. For convention, instead of writing $*(a, b)$, we write ab . The set G and the operation $*$ follow the following axioms:

1. Associativity: for any $a, b, c \in G$ $(ab)c = a(bc)$.
2. Identity: There exists an element $e \in G$ such that for all $g \in G$, $ge = eg = g$.
3. Inverses: for any element $g \in G$ there exists another element $h \in G$ such that $gh = hg = e$. We usually write h as g^{-1} .

These rules at first are incredibly simple, but they allow for some interesting and beautiful structure to emerge. We will now look through a few examples of some common groups.

Example 1.1 (The integers with addition). The set of integers $\mathbb{Z}$ with addition $+$ is a group. We write this as $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$. Addition on $\mathbb{Z}$ is associative since $(a + b) + c = a + (b + c)$ follows directly from the associativity of addition, which holds by construction of the integers. The identity is 0 as given any integer $a \in \mathbb{Z}$ $a + 0 = 0 + a = a$ $\forall a \in \mathbb{Z}$. For any $a \in \mathbb{Z}$, its inverse is simply $-a$ as $a + (-a) = (-a) + a = 0$.

Other common examples of groups are $(\mathbb{R}, +)$, $(\mathbb{C}, *)$ and $(\mathbb{Q}, *)$. These are all basic examples that can easily be proven.

Definition 1.2 (Abelian Groups). A group G is an abelian group if for any $a, b \in G$:

$$ab = ba$$

All of the groups mentioned prior are examples of abelian groups. We will now look at non-abelian groups.

Example 1.2 (Symmetric groups). Let X_n be the set of bijective functions from $\{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ to itself. Combining this set with the operation of function

composition $\circ$, we have the group $\mathcal{S}_n$. To explain this, we will focus on the group $\mathcal{S}_3$ which is the group of bijective functions from $\{1, 2, 3\}$ to itself. Consider an element $f \in \mathcal{S}_3$ where $f(1) = 2, f(2) = 3, f(3) = 1$. We can write this as: $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 2 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ Or we can write it as (123) . For the rest of this document, we will be writing elements of $\mathcal{S}_n$ in the second version presented (known as cycle notation). For the identity element of this group, it will simply be id_n , and for an arbitrary element $f \in \mathcal{S}_n$, the inverse is f^{-1} .

Example 1.3 (General Linear Group). The set of square $n \times n$ invertible matrices under matrix multiplication is known as the General Linear group, denoted $GL(n, K)$, where K is a field and $n \in \mathbb{N}$.

Now that we have shown examples of abelian and non-abelian groups, we can move on to proving some basic facts about groups.

Lemma 1.1. Let G be a group. The following are true:

1. There exists at most 1 identity element
2. Every element $g \in G$ has a unique inverse g^{-1}
3. $(g^{-1})^{-1} = g$
4. $(ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1}$
5. if $ab = ac$ then $b = c$
6. if $ba = ca$ then $b = c$

Proof of 1

Let G be a group with 2 identity elements e and $\hat{e}$. Since they are both identities, that means for any $g \in G$, $eg = ge = e$ and $g\hat{e} = \hat{e}g = g$. Now let $g = e$. Via the property of the identity: $e\hat{e} = \hat{e}e = e$ and $\hat{e}e = e\hat{e} = \hat{e}$. Via the property of transitivity, $e = \hat{e}$

Proof of 2

Let $g \in G$ be given and let $a, b \in G$ be inverses for g . a and b are inverses for g which means $ga = ag = e$ and $gb = bg = e$. Consider agb . Using associativity, we can show that:

$$agb = (ag)b = eb = b$$

And

$$agb = a(gb) = ae = a$$

So $agb = a$ and $agb = b$, therefore $a = b$ implying the inverse element is unique.

Proof of 3

Let $g \in G$ and $g^{-1} \in G$ be given. By definition: $gg^{-1} = e$. Multiplying both right sides by $(g^{-1})^{-1}$ gets us:

$$gg^{-1}(g^{-1})^{-1} = e(g^{-1})^{-1} \implies$$

$$ge = (g^{-1})^{-1} \implies g = (g^{-1})^{-1}$$

Which confirms $(g^{-1})^{-1} = g$.

Proof of 4

let $a, b \in G$ and let $c \in G$ be the inverse of ab . This means:

$$(ab)c = e$$

Multiplying the left side by a^{-1} :

$$a^{-1}(ab) = a^{-1} \implies (a^{-1}a)bc = a^{-1} \implies bc = a^{-1}$$

If we now multiply the left hand side by b^{-1} we get:

$$b^{-1}bc = b^{-1}a^{-1} \implies (b^{-1}b)c = b^{-1}a^{-1} \implies c = b^{-1}a^{-1}$$

So we have $c = b^{-1}a^{-1}$ and since we defined c to be the inverse of (ab) i.e. $(ab)^{-1}$, we have shown that $(ab)^{-1} = b^{-1}a^{-1}$.

Proof 4 and 5 are exercises for the reader.

1.2 Subgroups

Definition 1.3 (Definition of a subgroup). Let $(G, *)$ be a group. A subset $H \subseteq G$ is called a subgroup of G if H itself forms a group under the operation $*$ if H is a subgroup of G we write $H \leq G$.

For H to be a group under the same operation, it must inherit the group axioms. Since H lives inside G , it automatically takes associativity, and therefore only 3 rules must be verified to see if H is a subgroup of G .

In simple terms, $H \leq G$ if and only if:

1. Closure: $\forall a, b \in H, ab \in H$
2. Identity: The identity element $e \in G$ is also in H
3. Inverses $\forall g \in H, g^{-1} \in H$

Checking all of these axioms for every subgroup will become tedious. Instead, we use Theorems to help.

Theorem 1.1 (Subgroup test). A non-empty subset $H \subseteq G$ is a subgroup ($H \leq G$) if and only if:

1. $\forall a, b \in H \implies ab \in H$
2. $\forall a \in H \implies a^{-1} \in H$

The proof in the $\implies$ direction is trivial, so we will focus on the proof in the $\impliedby$ direction. i.e., if a non-empty subset of G follows those 2 conditions, then it is a subgroup in G .

Let $a, b, c \in H$. Since $H \subseteq G$, these elements are also in G . Because the operation $*$ is associative for all elements in G , it is automatically associative for the elements in H . Closure and inverses are both guaranteed by the 2 conditions of the subgroup test. Since we know H is non-empty, it implies there exists one element $x \in H$. Condition 2 tells us that $x^{-1} \in H$ and condition 1 tells us that $xx^{-1} \in H$ and since $xx^{-1} = e$, then $e \in H$ and therefore H has an identity element. Since H has met the requirements of all of the group axioms, it must be a subgroup of G . i.e., $H \leq G$ $\square$

With this theorem, we can prove that groups are subgroups of others more quickly.

Example 1.4 (The integers are a subgroup of the real numbers). $(\mathbb{Z}, +)$ is a subgroup of $(\mathbb{R}, +)$

For any group G , the trivial group $\{e\}$ and the group itself are always subgroups.

Definition 1.4 (The order of an element). Let G be a group and let $g \in G$ be given. Suppose $g^n = e$ i.e. $\underbrace{gg \dots g}_{n \text{ times}} = e$. The smallest positive integer n when this is true is called the order of g . We denote this $|g| = n$.

If there does not exist an n then we say that the order of g is infinite. Note that the only element to have order 1 is the identity element itself. Furthermore, the order of a *group* is simply the number of elements within it. A classic example of this can be the 90° rotation matrix A in the general linear group. the order of A would be 4. Another example is a reflection s which has order 2.

Definition 1.5 (Cyclic groups). Let G be a group and let $g \in G$ with order n be given. We define the *cyclic* group to be $\langle g \rangle = \{e, g, g^2, \dots, g^{n-1}\}$. We call g the generator of this group.

We say a group is cyclic if there exists an element $g \in G$ such that $\langle g \rangle = G$. An example is the group of integers represented by addition, i.e. $\langle 1 \rangle = \mathbb{Z}$. Since 1 has infinite order, we say that this group is infinite. We can have multiple generators for 1 group.

Consider 2 elements a, b with orders n and m respectively; we can define a group generated by these 2 elements as:

$$\langle a, b \rangle = \{a^x b^y \mid x, y \in \mathbb{Z}^+\}$$

It is clear that any cyclic group is also abelian.

1.3 Homomorphisms

Homomorphisms are very useful in abstract algebra as they preserve the algebraic operation between 2 structures, allowing us to translate problems from one system to another where they might be easier to solve.

In group theory, we define a group in the following way:

Definition 1.6 (A group homomorphism). Given 2 groups $(G, *)$ and $(H, \star)$, a homomorphism is a function $f : G \rightarrow H$ such that for any $a, b \in G$:

$$f(a * b) = f(a) \star f(b)$$

This definition essentially states that group operations are preserved between the 2 groups. With this definition, we can already prove some interesting consequences.

Lemma 1.2. Let G and H be groups. Let f be a homomorphism between G and H . The following are true:

1. $f(e_G) = e_H$
2. $\forall g \in G, f(g^{-1}) = f(g)^{-1}$
3. $\forall g \in G, f(g^n) = f(g)^n$
4. If $g \in G$ has finite order i.e. $|g| = n$ then the order of $|f(g)|$ must divide n

Proof of 1:

Let G and H be groups and let f be a homomorphism from G to H . Consider $f(e_G)$, since f is a homomorphism, it means:

$$f(e_G) = f(e_G * e_G) = f(e_G) \star f(e_G)$$

Which implies $f(e_G) = f(e_G) \star f(e_G)$. Multiplying both sides by $f(e_G)^{-1}$ will get us:

$$e_H = f(e_G)$$

Proof of 2:

Let $g \in G$. Because of (1) we have:

$$f(g) \star f(g^{-1}) = f(g * g^{-1}) = f(e_G) = e_H$$

This implies that $f(g) \star f(g^{-1}) = e_H$ which makes $f(g^{-1})$ the inverse of $f(g)$ which means:

$$f(g^{-1}) = f(g)^{-1}$$

Proof of 3:

Consider $f(g^n) = f(\underbrace{gg \dots g}_{n \text{ times}}) = f(g) \star f(g) \star f(g) \star \dots \star f(g) = f(g)^n$

Proof of 4:

Let $g \in G$ have order n and let $f(g)$ have order k . Because of (3), we know that $f(g^n) = f(g)^n$, which implies that

$$f(g)^n = f(g^n) = f(e_G) = e_H$$

Now using something called the *Division Algorithm* (this will be expanded upon further in later sections), we want to show that k must divide n , therefore we can write n in terms of k :

$$n = qk + r \quad \text{where } 0 \leq r < k$$

Substituting this back into our equation gets us:

$$e_H = f(g)^n = f(g)^{qk+r} = (f(g)^k)^q \star f(g)^r$$

Since we defined the order of $f(g)$ to be k , we can simplify to:

$$e_H = f(g)^r$$

However, this would imply that r is the order of $f(g)$ which would contradict our initial statement that being the order of $f(g)$ is equal to k . Therefore, $r = 0$ and thus:

$$n = qk \implies k \mid n$$